

What does “closed” mean in Vancouver’s 3-1-1 service-request data?

An independent look at the City’s public 3-1-1 records: can a closed case be read as a completed service?

Requests opened 1 Jan – 31 Dec 2025 (Vancouver time) · 272,580 records · Data extracted 2026-09-11 · Prepared by Abhijit Mishra

99.0%

of 2025 requests were closed at extraction

269,798 of 272,580 records

57.5%

of closed cases record “Service provided”

155,210 of 269,798 closed cases

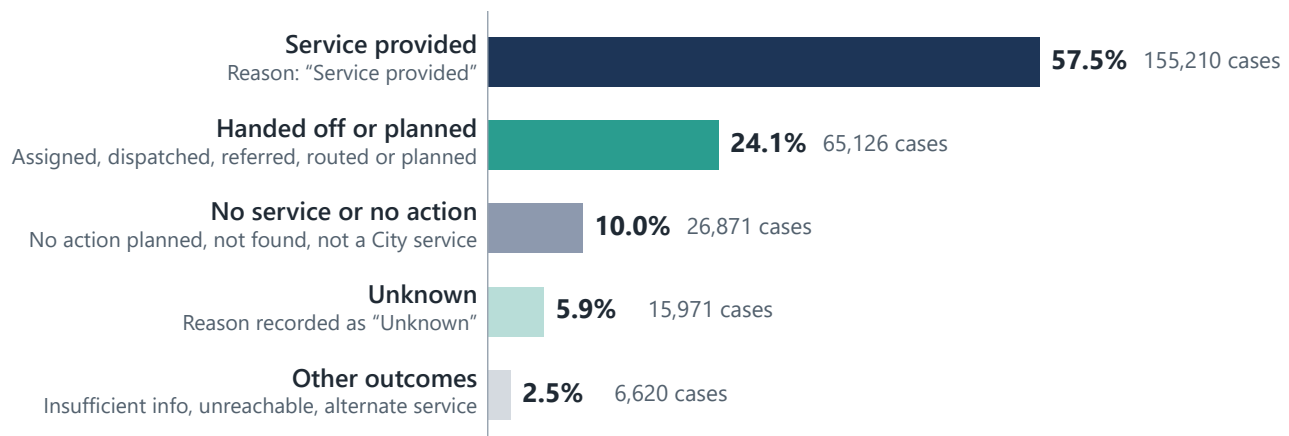
24.1%

of closed cases record a handoff or planned work

65,126 of 269,798 closed cases

Just over half of closed cases record that the service was provided

The rest record handoffs, decisions not to act or no specified outcome: a count of closed cases is not a count of completed services.



Share of 269,798 closed cases; 2,782 open cases excluded. Analyst-defined groups of the 17 published closure reasons (Appendix B).

Closed is a record status, not proof of completion. Whether the work was done is a separate fact, shown only through the closure reason, and even “Service provided” needs its meaning confirmed.

“Closed” covers several outcomes

Closures also record handoffs (24.1%), decisions not to act (10.0%) and “Unknown” (5.9%).

The mix varies by department

Across the 12 largest departments, “Service provided” ranges from 1.8% to 86.7% of each department’s closed cases (Appendix A).

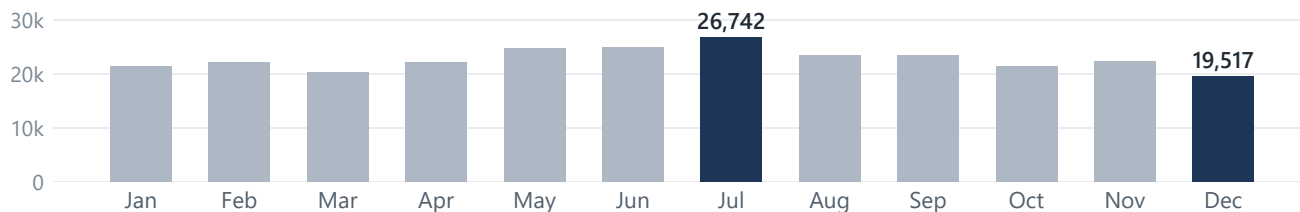
Unclear outcomes are concentrated

99.4% of “Unknown” closures come from just two request types.

Where the pattern shows up

Demand was spread across the whole year

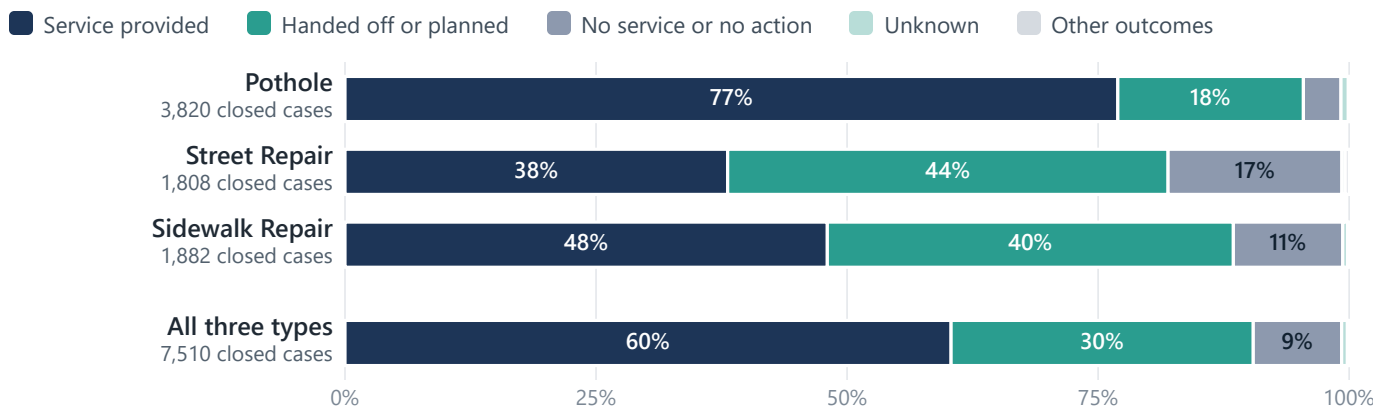
Monthly requests ranged from 19,517 (December) to 26,742 (July): a full year of activity, not one peak.



All 272,580 records, by Vancouver-local opening month.

In street and sidewalk repair, what “closed” records depends on the request type

“Service provided” ranges from 38% of closed street-repair cases to 77% of pothole cases, so one closure count would blur different outcomes.



Share of closed cases per request type; 140 open cases excluded. Chosen from seven candidate families: it passed all four selection tests with the most handoff or planned closures (30% vs 11% for the other qualifier).

Handoffs are common in repairs

44% of street-repair and 40% of sidewalk-repair closures record a handoff or planned work (potholes: 18%).

Planned work closes later

Sidewalk closures recorded as “Further action has been planned” took a median of 9 recorded calendar days ($n = 551$); “Service provided,” 5 ($n = 904$).

Not every other outcome is unfinished

17% of street-repair closures record a decision or finding, such as no action planned.

What we can conclude

- “Closed” covers several recorded outcomes.
- About a quarter record a handoff or planned work.
- Completion of planned work is not published.

What needs confirmation with City staff

- What each closure reason means, including “Service provided.”
- Whether completion of handed-off work is recorded.
- Whether “Unknown” is a default for some intake paths.

RECOMMENDATION

Make closure outcomes visible in reporting

Four options compared

Clarifying outcome definitions scored highest: it addresses the pattern found with the least effort and risk.

OPTION	SCORE (OF 35)	MAIN CONSIDERATION
Keep the current interpretation	18	No effort, but “closed” keeps mixing recorded outcomes.
Clarify outcome definitions in reporting	31	Targets the pattern found; uses fields already recorded; no system change.
Improve intake guidance for repairs	17	Weak evidence: few repair closures record missing information.
Add a recurring exception-review report	25	Useful later, but depends on agreed definitions first.

Seven criteria (decision benefit, evidence, effort, risk, data needs, stakeholder impact, scalability), each scored 1–5 where 5 is more favourable. Preliminary outside-in judgement; needs validation with City staff.

RECOMMENDATION

Pilot outcome-aware closure reporting for street and sidewalk repair

It addresses one status covering different recorded outcomes, needs no system change, and lays the foundation for later exception reviews.

Already applied in this study

- Outcome shares use closed cases; open cases shown separately.
- All 17 original closure reasons kept and mapped.
- Durations compared within request type and outcome.

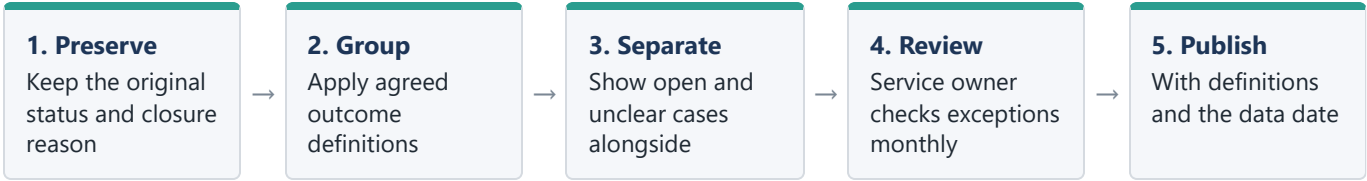
Proposed: needs validation with City staff

- Agreed definitions for each closure reason.
- An outcome-split view for the pilot service.
- A way to link completion of planned or referred work to the case.

How the pilot would work

Proposed reporting flow

Each step keeps the published data intact and adds only definitions and review.



Three implementation steps

STEP	WHO (PROPOSED)	SUCCESS MEASURE
1. Confirm definitions Agree what each repair closure reason means and where completion is recorded.	Streets Operations service owner, 3-1-1 intake lead, reporting analyst, business analyst	Every closure reason used for repairs has an agreed written definition.
2. Pilot the report Three monthly cycles of an outcome-split view for street and sidewalk repair.	Reporting analyst, service owner	Users can tell recorded provision from handoffs in a short check; “Unknown” share tracked (2025 public baseline: 0.6%).
3. Evaluate and decide Review usefulness and effort, then expand, adjust or stop.	Sponsor, service owner, business analyst	A decision against agreed criteria. Targets are set only after baselines are measured.

Limitations

- Public data only; no interviews or internal documents.
- Closure reasons describe the record, not a verified outcome.
- No case ID, so referrals and reopenings can’t be traced.
- Calendar-day durations from a date-only field; one year of data.

Sources

City of Vancouver Open Data Portal, “3-1-1 service requests” dataset and catalogue record (opendata.vancouver.ca), extracted 2026-09-11.

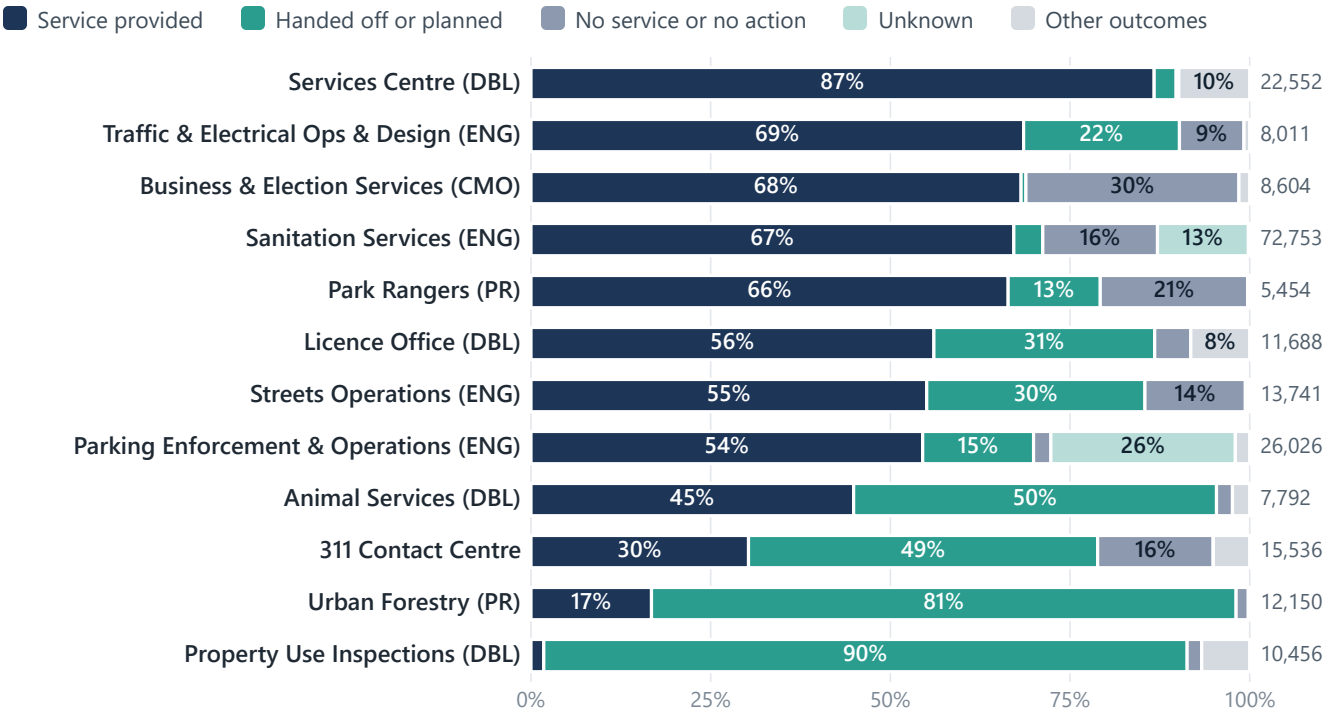
City of Vancouver, “Report issues and request services with Van311” (vancouver.ca/van311.aspx).

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Why one closure rate cannot compare departments

The outcome mix behind “closed” varies widely across departments

Among the 12 largest departments (79.6% of closed cases), “Service provided” ranges from 1.8% to 86.7% of each department’s closed cases, so closure rates are not comparable without the outcome split.



Share of each department’s own closed 2025 cases, sorted by the “Service provided” share. Numbers at right are closed cases. Three long names are shortened.

Where “Unknown” comes from

REQUEST TYPE	UNKNOWN	RATE IN TYPE	SHARE OF ALL
Garbage Bin Request	9,203	53.4%	57.6%
Parking Enforcement Transfer	6,680	99.1%	41.8%

Sensitivity check

CLOSED-CASE SHARE	ALL RECORDS	EXCL. FLAGGED
Service provided	57.5%	60.2%
Handed off or planned	24.1%	23.2%
No service or no action	10.0%	10.4%
Unknown	5.9%	3.6%

“Excl. flagged” drops four administrative-sounding request types (12,033 records; 257,765 closed cases remain).

Recorded calendar days to closure

OUTCOME (CITYWIDE)	ELIGIBLE N	MEDIAN	90TH PCT
Service provided	155,210	4	18
Handed off or planned	65,116	1	9
No service or no action	26,871	3	17
Unknown	15,971	0	0
All outcomes combined	269,788	2	16

Eligible closed cases (269,788); open cases and 10 cases with a close date before the opening date are excluded (all 10 are in “Handed off or planned,” so its n is 65,116 rather than 65,126). Nearest-rank percentiles; not resolution or service-delivery time. The combined median describes no single group.

How the figures were produced

- **Source:** City of Vancouver open dataset “3-1-1 service requests,” API export 2026-09-11 02:59 UTC.
- **Cohort:** requests whose opening timestamp, converted from UTC to Vancouver time, falls in 2025 (272,580 records).
- **Denominators:** outcome shares use closed cases (269,798); demand counts use all records.
- **Recorded calendar days to closure:** close date minus local opening date; 269,788 eligible closed cases. Open cases and 10 negative values are excluded, not set to zero.
- **Outcome groups** are the analyst’s interpretation of published wording. Original values are preserved and mapped below.
- **Privacy:** address and coordinate fields were removed before analysis; geography appears only as totals.
- **Tools:** Python for extraction and profiling; an Excel workbook (Power Query and formulas) recalculates every figure.
- **Verification:** every figure is read from the workbook’s saved values and listed with its cell in Numbers_Trace_v2.csv (205 entries; headline counts also match the independent Python calculation). Option scores are analyst judgement, labelled as such. Report text checked against all 40,421 published address strings: 0 matches.

Closure-reason mapping (all 17 published values)

PUBLISHED CLOSURE REASON	REPORT CATEGORY	WORKBOOK GROUP (ANALYST-DEFINED)	CLOSED	OPEN
Service provided	Service provided	1. Service recorded as provided	155,210	1
Further action has been planned	Handed off or planned	2. Work assigned, referred or continuing	23,220	2
Assigned to inspector	Handed off or planned	2. Work assigned, referred or continuing	14,185	3
Dispatched to Crew	Handed off or planned	2. Work assigned, referred or continuing	3,117	0
Referred to another service group	Handed off or planned	2. Work assigned, referred or continuing	10,368	17
Closed automatically and sent to service group	Handed off or planned	2. Work assigned, referred or continuing	14,236	10
Reviewed and no action planned	No service or no action	3. No service or no action recorded	14,931	0
Issue not found or inaccessible	No service or no action	3. No service or no action recorded	8,021	0
Not a city provided service / jurisdiction	No service or no action	3. No service or no action recorded	3,726	0
Outside of Parameters (Sanitation)	No service or no action	3. No service or no action recorded	133	0
Contaminated (Sanitation)	No service or no action	3. No service or no action recorded	60	0
Insufficient info	Other outcomes	4. Insufficient information / could not proceed	4,608	0
Customer unreachable	Other outcomes	4. Insufficient information / could not proceed	390	0
Unknown	Unknown	5. Unknown or N/A	15,971	0
N/A	Unknown	5. Unknown or N/A	0	2,749
Alternate Service Required	Other outcomes	6. Other - requires review	1,616	0
Information received	Other outcomes	6. Other - requires review	6	0

“Other outcomes” combines workbook groups 4 and 6 for display only. “N/A” appears only on open cases in 2025.

Sources. City of Vancouver. *3-1-1 service requests* [dataset] and catalogue record. <https://opendata.vancouver.ca/explore/dataset/3-1-1-service-requests/> (accessed 2026-09-11). City of Vancouver. *Report issues and request services with Van311*. <https://vancouver.ca/van311.aspx> (accessed September 2026). Contains information licensed under the Open Government Licence – Vancouver.